

Media, Power, and the Subversion or Restoration of Democracy in Latin America

We explore how television shaped political reality and determined democratic outcomes across Latin America from the 1970s through the 1990s.

In one case, television was corrupted and silenced to maintain a façade of democracy; in the other, it became the channel through which democracy reawakened.



Setting the Stage: Television and the Politics of Visibility

From the 1970s through the democratic wave of the 1990s, mass media became the most powerful tool for shaping political reality in Latin America. Radio and print had long mediated the public sphere, but television transformed the scale and immediacy of communication. It could reach millions simultaneously, transmit emotion as well as information, and—crucially—link rulers to citizens without the mediation of parties or institutions.

Authoritarian rulers quickly understood that whoever controlled television could control the narrative of legitimacy. Likewise, democratic reformers learned that even limited access to the airwaves could erode the walls of fear and censorship. The cases of Peru under Alberto Fujimori and Vladimiro Montesinos, and Chile under Augusto Pinochet, illustrate two sides of this same coin.

Understanding how these media dynamics unfolded allows us to see why the control—or liberation—of television often determines whether democratic institutions endure or collapse.





The Peruvian Case: Montesinos and the Market for Corruption

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Power Behind the Throne

When Fujimori came to power in 1990, Peru was a nation in disarray: hyperinflation, insurgency, and discredited political parties. Into this vacuum stepped Vladimiro Montesinos, a disgraced ex-officer who became the de facto architect of government as head of the National Intelligence Service (SIN). Montesinos grasped a fundamental truth about modern authoritarianism: it is not always imposed by force, but by buying the appearance of consent.

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Mechanisms of Control

Montesinos created a system of perpetual dependency. Monthly payments ensured loyalty, while videotaped evidence served as blackmail. Violence was used sparingly; the true coercion was psychological and informational. Through these networks, he merged executive, legislative, and judicial powers under the veneer of legality—an echo of Madison's warning that such accumulation is the "very definition of tyranny."

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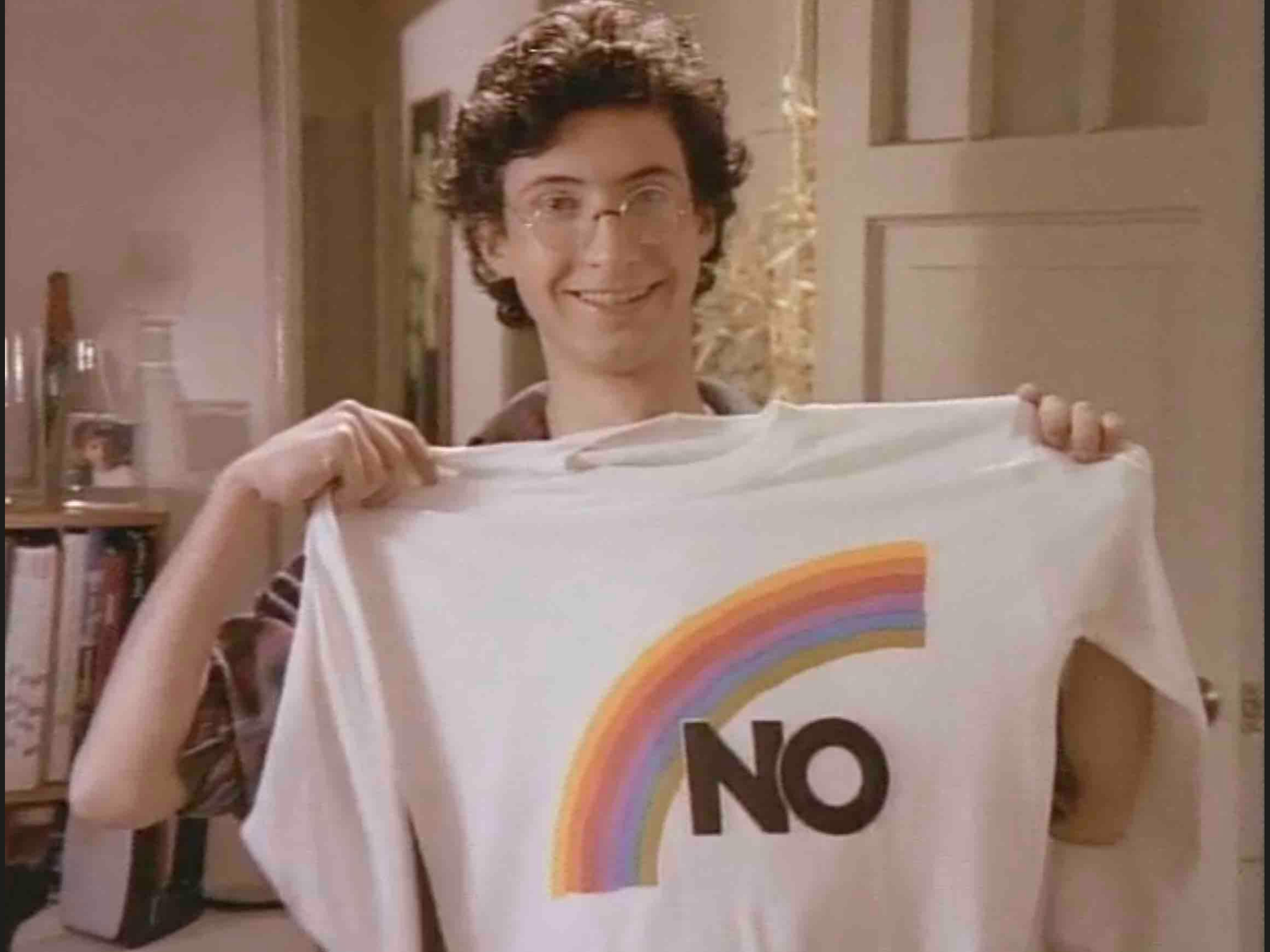
Lies, Videotapes, and the Price of Compliance

Montesinos's genius and eventual downfall lay in his obsession with documentation. He demanded written receipts for bribes and filmed his transactions—the now infamous *vladivideos*. By analyzing these tapes, McMillan and Zoido revealed a the political economy of corruption: **television was the most expensive institution to capture**. A single TV channel cost Montesinos more than all opposition politicians combined, confirming that media, not parliament, was the regime's real check on power.

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Collapse Through Exposure

In 2000, a single videotape showing Montesinos bribing a congressman for \$15,000 triggered the regime's implosion. Fujimori fled to Japan; Montesinos was arrested and tried. The downfall revealed a paradox of informational control: the same medium used to suppress truth became the instrument of exposure.



The Chilean Case: Television and the Democratic Defeat of Pinochet

Context and the 1988 Plebiscite

Chile's seventeen-year dictatorship sought to blend repression with constitutionalism. The 1980 constitution scheduled a plebiscite in 1988 to determine whether General Augusto Pinochet would rule for another eight years. Confident of victory, the regime permitted opposition access to television for fifteen minutes per night during the campaign. That space—the *franja del No*—became a turning point in Latin American political communication.

Measuring Television's Impact

Using survey and voting data, González and Prem (2018) find that greater access to television increased opposition votes by about two percentage points per standard deviation of exposure, even after controlling for prior political leanings and socioeconomic variables. Crucially, radio exposure had no similar effect, showing that it was not media penetration per se, but the visual, emotional impact of television that moved voters.

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The Campaign of Joy

The opposition's broadcast offered humor, music, and hope under the slogan "Chile, la alegría ya viene" (Chile, joy is coming). In contrast to the regime's fear-based messages, the franja portrayed ordinary Chileans envisioning a democratic future. It personalized politics, showing not ideology but everyday life. For millions, it was their first glimpse of dissent not framed as chaos or subversion.

Television as a Public Sphere

The franja temporarily shattered the regime's information monopoly. It created a shared national conversation, blending political argument with cultural performance. The campaign's success reflected not only its message but its capacity to unify a fragmented opposition, showing that cooperation, not polarization, could defeat authoritarianism.

Comparative Reflections: Two Media Regimes, Two Logics of Power

Peru: Television as Weapon

- Television was the pillar of authoritarian stability
- Montesinos recognized that capturing it was more efficient than censoring it
- By bribing broadcasters, he neutralized public scrutiny and fabricated consensus
- The regime's strength lay in secrecy, transaction, and control of narrative
- Used television to suppress pluralism and monopolize information flows

Chile: Television as Liberation

- Television became the catalyst of democratic awakening
- The *Franja del No* bypassed fear and reframed the meaning of citizenship
- Opposition used it to re-humanize politics and create shared conversation
- A carefully controlled institutional opening allowed citizens to reclaim sovereignty
- Demonstrated that even partial media liberalization can trigger democratic change

The Dual Nature of Media Power

Television can be a weapon of manipulation or a stage for liberation, depending on who holds the microphone and what message is broadcast. Both cases expose the fragility of institutional checks in presidential systems when information flows are monopolized.

Executive Dominance Destroys Accountability

In Peru, the executive's covert dominance over other branches destroyed accountability through bribery and information control. In Chile, Pinochet's constitution codified executive dominance, but a moment of communicative pluralism allowed democratic forces to prevail.

Institutions, Media, and the Logic of Authoritarian Durability



Executive Predominance and Institutional Capture

These cases embody the perils of unchecked presidentialism. Montesinos's network blurred constitutional boundaries, while Pinochet's constitution codified executive dominance. Both neutralized the legislature and judiciary—one through bribery, the other through design. The readings confirm patterns we've seen in executive–legislative relations throughout the course.



Media as Informational Infrastructure

Mass media operates as a fourth branch of government. When independent, it sustains vertical accountability; when captured, it consolidates executive rule. Montesinos paid most to neutralize television precisely because it was the only institution capable of influencing public opinion outside his control. The Chilean experience shows that even partial media liberalization can trigger democratic change once citizens encounter alternative narratives.



Legitimacy and Resilience

From the perspective of the "legitimacy and resilience" framework, Peru's regime depended on performance legitimacy—economic recovery and security—reinforced by propaganda. Chile's depended on institutional legitimacy, claiming constitutional order and stability. Both were undone when informational legitimacy collapsed: when citizens stopped believing the official story.

Democracy depends not just on formal institutions, but on the informational infrastructure that allows citizens to hold power accountable. When that infrastructure is captured or corrupted, even constitutional democracies can become authoritarian facades.

From Television to Social Media



Television Era

Concentrated communication in few powerful channels. Unified the public sphere. Control meant capturing broadcasters.



Social Media Era

Infinite channels of communication. Risks fragmenting publics into echo chambers. Control means algorithmic manipulation.

The difference lies not in the technology itself but in who controls the flow of messages

Democracy depends on transparency, credible information, and institutions capable of resisting capture—whatever the medium through which power communicates. The lessons from Peru and Chile remain vital: whether through television broadcasts or viral tweets, the battle for democracy is ultimately a battle for the narratives that shape how citizens understand their world and their power within it.

